

Suspect in shelter assault remained in state system

Was relocated to another spot that housed families with kids

By Giulia McDonnell Nieto del Rio

GLOBE STAFF

PEABODY — A man accused of sexually assaulting an 11-year-old girl in a state shelter in early December was not removed from the system pending a police investigation, but was relocated to another state shelter that housed families with children, according to a police report obtained by the Globe.

The incident adds to questions about the state's oversight of its embattled shelter system, which has been under extreme pressure amid the arrival of thousands of new migrants. The Globe previously reported more than 1,000 serious incidents were reported at the shelters over a 20-month period.

The fifth-grade girl in the Peabody case said she was assaulted by a man on Dec. 9 in a stairwell of a Holiday Inn serving as a state shelter, and fought to get away, according to the police report. The police responded immediately, then referred the case to the office of Essex County District Attorney Paul F. Tucker for further investigation. The 32-year-old alleged assailant was not arrested, but instead that

SHELTERS, Page A10

Davis Square posters get emotions running high

Less-than-accurate depiction of proposed tower stirs the pot

By Spencer Buell

GLOBE STAFF

SOMERVILLE — If you've been to Davis Square for one of its many food and entertainment options, you know this stretch of Elm Street: Dragon Pizza, McKinnon's Meat Market, the Burren.

But the future of one of the most quintessential neighborhood business districts in the Boston area has been in flux. Owners of the segment on Elm tried to redevelop the property into 250 units of housing in 2019, but that fizzled. So did an effort to bid to build lab space.

Owners have pivoted again, this time aiming high — really high. They have proposed a 25-story tower of 500 apartments atop a space that for many years has been mom-and-pop stores and restaurants, but is also just a short walk from a Red Line MBTA stop at a time when housing near public transit has become a statewide priority.

So how would something like that look in a place like this?

Many neighbors got a first glimpse of it from, of all things, a paper flier. The developer and local housing advocates argue that the depiction is highly inaccurate. It was nonetheless an opening shot

FLIERS, Page A10



Army helicopter, jet collide midair at airport in D.C.

A large search-and-rescue operation was launched, and The Washington Post reported bodies were pulled from the Potomac River. The jet had 60 passengers and 4 crew. **A2.**

Trump backs off funding freeze

Rescinds order after backlash across country

By Zolan Kanno-Youngs, Maggie Haberman, and Annie Karni

NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — The White House on Wednesday rescinded a directive that froze trillions of dollars in federal grants and loans after the order led to mass

confusion and legal challenges that accused the Trump administration of violating the law.

The order, issued Monday night, was an attempt to purge the government of what President Trump has called a “woke” ideology. A federal judge in the District of Columbia temporarily blocked it Tuesday afternoon, but the lack of clarity sent schools, hospitals, nonprofits, and other organizations scrambling to understand if they had lost their financial support from

the government.

On Wednesday, Matthew J. Vaeth, the acting director for the Office of Management and Bud-

►Local arts, culture leaders wonder what's next. **B1.**
►Funding for climate projects no longer a sure thing. **B1.**

get, told federal agencies that the memo freezing aid had been “rescinded.”

In a brief notice, Vaeth said: “If you have questions about im-

plementing the president's executive orders, please contact your agency general counsel.”

The decision to pull the directive was a significant reversal and the first major capitulation by Trump since returning to the White House. Less than two weeks into his term, he has not hesitated to use his executive power to reshape the federal government in his image and rid the workforce of any dissent.

Karoline Leavitt, the White

FREEZE, Page A7

CHANGING VIEWS ON VACCINES, ABORTION

2023

‘There’s no vaccine that is safe and effective.’

WED.

‘I support vaccines.’

2024

‘I think we have to leave it to the women rather than the state.’

WED.

‘I have always believed abortion is a tragedy.’



BEN CURTIS/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Democrats expressed their opposition to Robert F. Kennedy Jr. on Wednesday while Republicans generally rallied around him.

Kennedy gets heat from unexpected source

Weakness on Medicare, Medicaid is exposed by a Republican at hearing

By Sam Brodey

GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — When Robert F. Kennedy Jr. sat for his first Senate confirmation hearing Wednesday, Democratic senators came prepared with sharp questions meant to interrogate his views and past statements on vaccines, abortion, and a number of other topics.

But the most potentially damaging moment for President Trump's pick for health chief came, in understated fashion, from a Republican senator — the same one who will chair Kennedy's next, and final, confirmation hearing in a different committee on Thursday.

During the hearing Wednesday, Senator Bill Cassidy, a Louisiana Republican, asked

Kennedy about the two most central programs operated by the department Kennedy is seeking to lead: Medicare and Medicaid, which collectively cover tens of millions of seniors, low-income Americans, and children.

“What thoughts,” Cassidy asked, “do you have about Medicaid reform?”

After asserting Medicaid wasn't working, Kennedy derided that the “premiums” and “deductibles” for the program were “too high.” But for the most part, premiums and deductibles aren't a feature of Medicaid. Kennedy then wrapped his answer by talking about Medicare, an entirely different program.

Gently, Cassidy tried to prompt Kennedy to provide any specifics to back up his ambiguous promises to “increase transparency”

and “increase accountability.” He didn't, and it was clear Kennedy was far out of his depth concerning even basic details of two programs that together account for more than 80 percent of the Department of Health and Human Services' annual budget.

While Democrats clashed with Kennedy over his antivaccine views and other controversies, sparking heated exchanges but offering little clarity, Senator Peter Welch, a Vermont Democrat, praised Cassidy for his simple but illuminating questions.

“Senator Cassidy did the best job, because he asked questions that went to the heart of, ‘What are we going to do about our health care system?’” Welch, who sits on the Senate Finance Committee that held Kennedy's first

KENNEDY, Page A6

More targeted

Trump gave US authorities broader power to deport undocumented immigrants accused of crimes, and said he plans to send the “worst” to a detention center in Guantanamo Bay. **A2.**

By Tal Kopan

GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Tens of thousands of dollars to write op-eds. Six-figure salaries from a think tank. High-dollar deals for speeches around the country. As President Trump's nominees to staff his administration face Senate confirmation, the public is getting a window into the myriad ways his hand-picked team made money.

Trump's nominees are collectively and individually wealthy, with much of their income derived from traditional private sector sources, like consulting, legal, or financial jobs. Several also had book deals and paid TV and media appearances. But the disclosures also reveal other, less ob-

vious sources of revenue that illuminate the workings of Washington.

None of the income sources for the Trump Cabinet are novel to them or Republicans, and their jobs at the Trump-aligned think tank were far from secret. But new financial disclosure filings together present a rare picture of just how lucrative some of these arrangements were — especially for out-of-power politicians who made much less while in elected office — and how MAGA has been good to even newcomers to the movement.

Collectively, the appointees made nearly \$390 million last year, according to the ethics disclosures released so far.

CABINET, Page A7

